

Quest for Speed

The 1930s brought a new thirst for speed among pilots, with ever more extreme aircraft being built. In the US huge engines were put into tiny stubby aircraft that were incredibly difficult to fly.

European enthusiasts were just as competitive, but their sporting aircraft tended to be a little slower and more practical, having been built for long-distance contests such as from England to South Africa and back, where reliability was critical.



△ Northrop Alpha 1930

Origin USA

Engine 420 hp Pratt & Whitney Wasp R-1340-SC1 air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 177 mph (285 km/h)

Jack Northrop's brilliant and very fast Alpha combined all-metal, semimonocoque fuselage with multicelled cantilever wings and wing fillets. It was built with seating for six passengers inside or a cargo hull.



△ Gee Bee R-2 1932

Origin USA

Engine 800 hp Pratt & Whitney R-1340 Wasp air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 296 mph (476 km/h)

Gee Bees are the aircraft most evocative of the golden age of American air racing in the 1930s. After the success of the Sportster, true racers like this were built to break records. Its wingspan was 25 ft (8 m).



◁ Arrow Active 2 1932

Origin UK

Engine 120 hp de Havilland Gypsy III air-cooled inverted 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 144 mph (230 km/h)

Only two Actives were built, of which this is the second. Failing to get military orders, they were flown as sports planes. Active 2 competed in the King's Cup in 1932-33, recording 137 mph (220 km/h).



△ Comper CLA7 Swift 1930

Origin UK

Engine Original 70 hp R/nw 90 hp Niagara II Pobjoy air-cooled 7-cylinder radial

Top speed 140 mph (225 km/h)

Small and light, constructed of fabric-covered spruce, Flight Lieutenant Nicholas Comper's Swift was built with increasingly powerful engines, making it an effective racing and sporting airplane.



△ Gee Bee Model Z Super Sportster 1931

Origin USA

Engine 535 hp Pratt & Whitney R-985 Wasp Jr air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 267 mph (430 km/h)

Granville Brothers crammed the largest possible engine into the smallest possible aircraft to win the 1931 Thompson Trophy in a new record speed. Fitted later with a 750 hp engine, it crashed during a record attempt.

